that “some are harmful.” Very harmful. As Fat Tony would say, “Tawk is cheap.” So Mark Spitznagel and I restarted the business of “robustifying” clients against the Black Swan (helping people get closer to the barbell of Chapter 11). We were convinced that the banking system was going to collapse under the weight of hidden risks—that such an event would be a white swan. It was moving from gray to white in color as the system was accumulating risks. The longer we had to wait for it, the more severe it would be. The collapse took place about a year and a half after the publication of the book. We had been expecting it and betting against the banking system for a long time (and protecting clients by making them Black Swan robust), but the reception of the Black Swan—and the absence of refutation that was not ad hominem—made us vastly more worried about the need for protection than ever before.

Like Antaeus, who lost strength when separated from contact with the earth, I needed connection to the real world, something real and applied, instead of focusing on winning arguments and trying to convince people of my point (people are almost always only convinced of what they already know). Sticking my neck out in the real world, lining up my life with my ideas by getting involved in trading, had a therapeutic effect, even apart from the vindication; just having a trade on the books gave me strength to not care. A few months before the onset of the crisis of 2008, I was attacked at a party by a Harvard psychologist who, in spite of his innocence of probability theory, seemed to have a vendetta against me and my book. (The most vicious and bitter detractors tend to be those with a competing product on the bookstore shelves.) Having a trade on allowed me to laugh at him—or, what is even worse, made me feel some complicity with him, thanks to his anger. I wonder what would have happened to the psychological state of another author, identical to me in all respects except that he had no involvement with trading and risk taking. When you walk the walk, whether successful or not, you feel more indifferent and robust to people’s opinion, freer, more real.

Finally, I got something out of my debates: the evidence that Black Swan events are largely caused by people using measures way over their heads, instilling false confidence based on bogus results. In addition to my befuddlement concerning why people use measures from Mediocristan outside those measures’ applicability, and believe in them, I had the inkling of a much larger problem: that almost none of the people who worked *professionally* with probabilistic measures knew what they were talking about, which was confirmed as I got into debates and panels with many hotshots, at least four with “Nobels” in economics. Really. And this problem was measurable, very easily testable. You